490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 17 OF 26

Exile: The Temple Falls

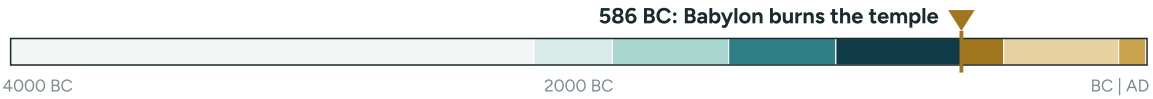
2 Kings 22–25; Jeremiah 29; 31; Daniel 3; 6



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 17



Introduction: The Darkest Day

In Lesson 16 the northern kingdom fell to Assyria in 722 BC. The southern kingdom of Judah watched it happen. It still had the temple, the city of Jerusalem, and a king from David's line. It lasted another 136 years. But in 586 BC the armies of Babylon broke through Jerusalem's walls, burned Solomon's temple to the ground, and carried the people away to a foreign land.

This was the lowest point in the whole Old Testament. Everything God had given seemed to be lost: the land promised to Abraham, the king promised to David, the temple where God's glory had come down. If you have ever felt that your life has collapsed and God is far away, this part of the story was written for you.

Yet the exile is also where some of the most beautiful promises in the Bible were given. In the rubble, God promised a new covenant, a new heart, and a King whose kingdom would never be destroyed. On our timeline: Babylon first takes captives in 605 BC, takes more in 597 BC, and destroys Jerusalem and the temple in 586 BC.

The Word: New Covenant

> **Jeremiah 31:31, 33** *"Behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and the house of Judah.... I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people."*

בְּרִית חֲדָשָׁה *(berit chadashah, "new covenant")*

God's promise to bind his people to himself with a heart that will not break the bond

בְּרִית (berit)

"covenant"

A binding, sworn relationship. The word we met with Noah, Abraham, Moses, and David.

+

חֲדָשָׁה (chadashah)

"new"

Fresh, renewed. Israel broke the covenant made at Sinai. God promised a new one that would do what the old could only point to.

Payoff: The night before he died, Jesus took a cup and said, "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20). The promise Jeremiah gave in the ashes of Jerusalem was kept at the cross. The phrase "New Testament" simply means "new covenant."

Part One: Why the Fall Came

Judah had good kings and bad kings. One of the worst was Manasseh, who reigned fifty-five years. He rebuilt the pagan shrines, put idols in the temple itself, practiced sorcery, and burned his own son as an offering. God said through his prophets that Manasseh had done "things more evil than all that the Amorites did, who were before him" (2 Kings 21:11), the very nations God had driven out of the land. Yet even Manasseh, dragged to Babylon in chains, humbled himself and cried out, and God heard him (2 Chr. 33:12–13). No one is too far gone for grace.

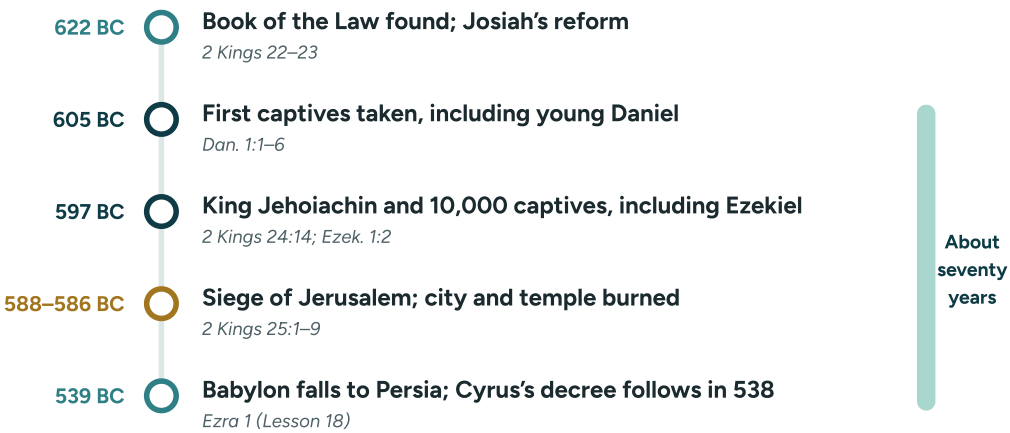
Later came Josiah, one of the best kings Judah ever had. While repairing the temple, the high priest found the Book of the Law, long neglected and unread. When it was read to Josiah, "he tore his clothes" (22:11). He led a great reform, tore down the idols, and renewed the covenant. "Before him there was no king like him, who turned to the LORD with all his heart and with all his soul and with all his might" (23:25). Yet the next verse is one of the saddest in Kings: "Still the LORD did not turn from the burning of his great wrath" (23:26). The verse gives the reason: "because of all the provocations with which Manasseh had provoked him." And the reform never reached the people's hearts. Through Jeremiah, God said Judah "did not return to me with her whole heart, but in pretense" (Jer. 3:10). After Josiah died, they went right back.

God sent prophet after prophet. The best known in these last years was Jeremiah, called by God as a young man (Jer. 1:6–7). He stood in the temple gate and told the people to stop trusting their religious building: "Do not trust in these deceptive words: 'This is the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD'" (7:4). They thought God would never let his own house fall. God asked through Jeremiah, "Has this house, which is called by my name, become a den of robbers in your eyes?" (7:11). Six hundred years later, Jesus would quote that verse in the courts of the rebuilt temple, on the same hill (Matt. 21:13).

The writer of Chronicles sums up why the end came: "The LORD, the God of their fathers, sent persistently to them by his messengers, because he had compassion on his people and on his dwelling place. But they kept mocking the messengers of God, despising his words and scoffing at his prophets, until the wrath of the LORD rose against his people, until there was no remedy" (2 Chr. 36:15–16).

Part Two: The Temple Falls

Babylon was the new superpower, under its king Nebuchadnezzar. It came in waves.



In 605 BC Nebuchadnezzar took some of Jerusalem's brightest young men to Babylon, including a teenager named Daniel (Dan. 1:1–6). In 597 BC he came back, took King Jehoiachin, emptied the temple treasury, and carried away "10,000 captives, and all the craftsmen and the smiths" (2 Kings 24:14), among them a young man from a priestly family named Ezekiel (Ezek. 1:1–3). Then in 588 BC, after Judah rebelled again, Babylon laid siege to Jerusalem. For about two and a half years the city slowly starved (2 Kings 25:1–3). In 586 BC the walls were breached, and the Babylonian commander "burned the house of the LORD and the king's house and all the houses of Jerusalem" (25:9). The temple Solomon had built nearly four hundred years earlier was gone.

Before it happened, God showed Ezekiel in a vision something even more terrible than the fire. He saw the glory of the LORD, the same glory that had filled the tabernacle and the temple, rise up and leave: "Then the glory of the LORD went out from the threshold of the house" and moved to the east gate, and then up to the mountain on the east side of the city (Ezek. 10:18–19; 11:23). God's glory had left the building before Babylon ever burned it.

The book of Lamentations is a funeral poem for the city: "How lonely sits the city that was full of people! How like a widow has she become" (Lam. 1:1). And in Babylon the exiles wept for Zion, the city of Jerusalem:



"On the willows there we hung up our lyres" (Ps. 137:2).

> **Psalm 137:1–4** *"By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion. On the willows there we hung up our lyres. For there our captors required of us songs, and our tormentors, mirth, saying, 'Sing us one of the songs of Zion!' How shall we sing the LORD's song in a foreign land?"*

Part Three: Faithful in a Foreign Land

How do you live for God when everything familiar is gone? God answered through a letter Jeremiah sent to the exiles. Do not sit and wait to go home. "Build houses and live in them; plant gardens and eat their produce. Take wives and have sons and daughters.... But seek the welfare of the city where I have sent you into exile, and pray to the LORD on its behalf, for in its welfare you will find your welfare" (Jer. 29:5–7). And there was hope: "When seventy years are completed for Babylon, I will visit you... and bring you back to this place" (29:10). The very next verse is the famous one: "For I know the plans I have for you." It was spoken to exiles who were told to settle in for seventy years. Most of them would die in Babylon. God's good plans were bigger than one lifetime.

Daniel and his three friends show what that looks like. They served the king faithfully, learned the language, and rose to high office. But they drew lines they would not cross. Daniel "resolved that he would not defile himself with the king's food" (Dan. 1:8). When Nebuchadnezzar set up a golden statue and ordered everyone to bow, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refused: "our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But if not, be it known to you, O king, that we will not serve your gods" (3:17–18). They were thrown into the fire, and the king saw "four men unbound, walking in the midst of the fire, and they are not hurt" (3:25). God had not left them alone in the fire.



"My God sent his angel and shut the lions' mouths" (Dan. 6:22).

Decades later, when Daniel was an old man, Babylon had fallen to the Medes and Persians, and King Darius ruled, a law made prayer to any god or man but the king a crime for thirty days. Daniel went home to his upper room, where the windows were open toward Jerusalem, and "got down on his knees three times a day and prayed and gave thanks before his God, as he had done previously" (6:10). He was thrown to the lions, and in the morning he said, "My God sent his angel and shut the lions' mouths" (6:22).

And God made a promise to the scattered exiles that changes everything: "Though I removed them far off among the nations… yet I have been a sanctuary to them for a while in the countries where they have gone" (Ezek. 11:16). The temple was gone. God was not. He himself became their sanctuary in Babylon.

CORE DOCTRINE 17 OF 26

The Sovereignty of God

God rules over all things, including nations, kings, and history. Babylon burned the temple because God sent it as his judgment, and Babylon fell when God said so. Nothing happens outside his plan. Yet God never does evil, and people are still responsible for what they choose. His plan is good.

KEY VERSES

Daniel 4:34–35; Jeremiah 25:9; Isaiah 46:9–10; Ephesians 1:11; Psalm 115:3

WHAT THE CHURCH CONFESSES

"The decrees of God are, his eternal purpose, according to the counsel of his will, whereby, for his own glory, he hath foreordained whatsoever comes to pass." (Westminster Shorter Catechism 7)

WHY IT MATTERS

When the headlines are frightening, God is still on his throne. Daniel could be faithful in Babylon because he knew who was really in charge.

Part Four: Promises in the Ashes

In the darkest chapter of their history, God gave his people some of his brightest promises. The writer of Lamentations, sitting in the ruins, said: "But this I call to mind, and therefore I have hope: The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness" (Lam. 3:21–23).

Through Jeremiah, God promised a **new covenant**. The old one was written on stone, and Israel broke it. The new one would be written on hearts, and it would rest on forgiveness: "For I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more" (Jer. 31:34). Through Ezekiel, God promised a **new heart** and his own **Spirit**: "I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you" (Ezek. 36:26–27). He showed Ezekiel a valley full of dry bones and asked, "Son of man, can these bones live?" Then he breathed into them, and they stood up, a vast army (37:1–10). God told Ezekiel, "these bones are the whole house of Israel" (37:11). God can bring a dead people back to life.

Through Daniel, God showed a vision of a heavenly King: "with the clouds of heaven there came one like a son of man.... And to him was given dominion and glory and a kingdom.... his dominion is an everlasting dominion, which shall not pass away, and his kingdom one that shall not be destroyed" (Dan. 7:13–14). Babylon's kingdom would fall. This one never would.

Promises in the Ashes, Kept in Christ

PROMISED IN EXILE		KEPT IN JESUS
A new covenant *Jer. 31:31*	→	"The new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20)
Sin remembered no more *Jer. 31:34*	→	One sacrifice for sins (Heb. 10:12, 17)
A new heart *Ezek. 36:26*	→	"A new creation" (2 Cor. 5:17)
My Spirit within you *Ezek. 36:27*	→	The Spirit poured out (Acts 2:33)
Dry bones live *Ezek. 37:5*	→	Raised with Christ (Eph. 2:5–6)
A Son of Man with an endless kingdom *Dan. 7:13–14*	→	"The Son of Man… coming with the clouds" (Mark 14:62)

"His mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning" (Lam. 3:22–23).

And the exile would end. Jeremiah had said seventy years (Jer. 25:11). Counted from the first captives in 605 BC, that brings you to about 539, when Babylon fell. Counted from the temple's fall in 586, it brings you to 516, when a new temple was finished. Daniel, reading Jeremiah's scroll, knew the time was nearly up (Dan. 9:2). That is where Lesson 18 picks up the story.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB The exiles had no temple and no altar. No sacrifices could be offered in Babylon. But more than a century earlier, God had given Isaiah words written for exactly this moment: comfort for a people in exile (Isa. 40:1–2), and a Servant who would be the sacrifice himself: "he was pierced for our transgressions; he was crushed for our iniquities; upon him was the chastisement that brought us peace" (Isa. 53:5).

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE The glory left the temple (Ezek. 10). It looked like the end of God dwelling with his people. But God was their sanctuary even in exile (Ezek. 11:16), and Ezekiel later saw the glory return to a new temple (43:4–5). That promise would be kept in a way no one expected: "the Word became flesh and dwelt among us, and we have seen his glory" (John 1:14).

The Turn: The Exile Who Brings Us Home

Six hundred years after the temple fell, Jesus rode toward Jerusalem, and when he saw the city, "he wept over it." He foresaw that it would fall again (Luke 19:41–44), and it did, to Rome, in AD 70. He wept as Jeremiah wept, because he loved the city that was rejecting him.

Then Jesus went through an exile of his own, the deepest one there has ever been. Adam and Eve were driven out of the garden. Israel was driven out of the land. Jesus was led outside the city walls, and on the cross he cried, "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Matt. 27:46). There, as our substitute, he bore the Father's just wrath against the sin that sent us into exile. He was still the beloved Son, and he went into that darkness for us, so that we could be brought home.

The night before, he had already told his disciples what his death meant: "This cup that is poured out for you is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20). Everything Jeremiah and Ezekiel promised comes through him: sins forgiven and remembered no more, God's law written on the heart, the Holy Spirit living within. And at his trial he told the high priest that he is the Son of Man from Daniel's vision: "you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven" (Mark 14:62).

The New Testament calls Christians "sojourners and exiles" (1 Pet. 2:11). This world is not yet our home. So we do what Jeremiah told the exiles: we build, plant, marry, work, and seek the good of the cities where God has put us, while we wait for the true home Jesus has secured. If your life feels like exile right now, hear Lamentations again: his mercies are new every morning. And if you are far from God, the One who went into exile for sinners is calling you home. Turn to him and trust him today.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1 **Read the promise.** Read Jeremiah 31:31–34 and Luke 22:19–20 together. Thank Jesus for the new covenant in his blood.

2 **Seek your city's welfare.** Pray for your town by name this week, and do one concrete thing for its good.

3 **Draw a line.** Daniel resolved ahead of time what he would not do. Name one line you will not cross, and ask God for courage to hold it.

4 **Keep your windows open.** Set a regular time and place to pray each day, as Daniel did, and keep it.

5 **Lament honestly.** If you are grieving, read Psalm 137 and Lamentations 3:19–24. Psalm 137 ends with raw, angry words. God lets grieving people say them to him, and he hands judgment over to himself. Bring your sorrow to God, then call to mind his mercy.

6 **Memorize Lamentations 3:22–23.** "The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; his mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

Before Lesson 18: *Read Ezra 1 and 3, Nehemiah 8, and Malachi 3–4. Lesson 18 follows the exiles home, the rebuilding of the temple, and four hundred quiet years of waiting.*

For Discussion

1. Judah trusted that God would never let his own temple fall. What "sure things" do people trust instead of God himself?
2. Josiah's reform was sincere, yet the nation did not change. Why can outward reform fail to change a heart?
3. Psalm 137 asks, "How shall we sing the LORD's song in a foreign land?" Have you ever felt that way? What helped?
4. God told the exiles to seek the welfare of Babylon. What would it look like for you to seek the good of your city?
5. Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego said, "But if not." What does it mean to trust God even if he does not rescue you the way you want? How does the cross show that God is good even when he says no?
6. The new covenant promises forgiveness, a new heart, and the Spirit. Which of these do you most need to believe today?
7. Jesus went into the deepest exile on the cross. How does that change the way you see your own seasons of feeling far from God?

Sources & For Further Study

- On the dates of Judah's fall (605, 597, 586 BC): Edwin R. Thiele, *The Mysterious Numbers of the Hebrew Kings*; Eugene H. Merrill, *Kingdom of Priests*.
- On the new covenant: O. Palmer Robertson, *The Christ of the Covenants*; Westminster Confession of Faith 7.6.
- For further reading: Philip Graham Ryken, *Jeremiah and Lamentations* (Preaching the Word); Iain M. Duguid, *Ezekiel* (NIV Application Commentary); Dale Ralph Davis, *The Message of Daniel*.



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